upbringing and moves on to her evolution away from home. She uses the language of borders and division to emphasize the violence of Jim Crow society and authority on her youth. For example, when she was four years old and the Davis family moved to a house atop a hill on Center Street in Birmingham from housing projects nearby, the reaction from her new neighbors was indelible: “Almost immediately after we moved there the white people got together and decided on a border line between them and us. Center Street became the line of demarcation.”[75] Davis emphasizes being raised in networks of support and the expansive activism of the black left, and yet the dangers of the Jim Crow South and the confining nature of everyday life were everywhere: “The provincialism of Birmingham bothered me. … I could not define or articulate the dissatisfaction. I simply had the sensation of things closing in on me.”[76] Davis also recalls her experience as a high school student in New York, where she learned to cope with being an outsider: “I could always tear away a piece of the wall and slip out to other worlds.”[77] For Davis, the wall functions here as a metaphor for reality and the status quo. In each case, she uses the language of walls and borders to express the confinement of racism and segregation she experienced.

In the section “Waters,” Davis describes her trip to Cold War Berlin. She tells of having spent most of her time easily passing into East Berlin during her school visit and alternately reports her reentry into West Germany afterward as being far more difficult. As she narrates, she was detained when trying to leave West Berlin for Frankfurt: “When the West German police said they were going to detain me at the airport,” she states, “I was certain they were going to accuse me of being too friendly with the people in the GDR—and of course, they would have been correct.” Davis goes on to point out that she was detained because she had failed to properly register her address in Frankfurt. “I could never get used to the incredible bureaucracy in which one must become embroiled merely as a prerequisite for living an ordinary life,”[78] she writes. She inverts the stereotypical treatment of East Germany as a police state, noting the repressive situation she faced in West Germany, where the physical wall was paced with a state of overbearing surveillance. That story reinforces her earlier account of housing discrimination when she was misrecognized as a Turkish “guest worker” in Frankfurt. She notes that “half the adults had gone through the experience of Hitler. And in West Germany, unlike the German Democratic Republic, there had been no determined campaign to attack the fascist and racist attitudes